Session 5

2025-03-02

1 - The mountain detour

~18:30, 23 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party takes a short rest in cover. Sinsong leans on Guidance liberally to help Nyx scout an alternate route south.
2. The valley floor where the ambush waits is the only easy road. Eguzkilore argues that the cultists will hold the chokepoint with at least a couple of lookouts even after the rest move on, and Mialee agrees the original ambushers have probably repositioned. The party climbs up over the rocky shoulder of the hill rather than push through the defile again.
3. Nyx leads them along a narrow goat-track up the slope, the rest in single file behind her. The going is slow and the night is closing in.
4. Eguzkilore's foot rolls on a loose stone partway up; the rock skitters down the slope and starts a small avalanche of pebbles, loud enough to carry. Voices begin reacting from below.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Sinsong scrambles into his cultist robe. Nyx ducks into cover. Amidamaru shapes a magical illusion of a *forest deer* on the slope ahead of them, complete enough that the species and even the season's coat are convincing — the illusion startles when the cultist voices approach and bounds off into the brush. Two cultists below point at the retreating deer, exchange a few words and turn back.
6. Another hour of climb across the ridge takes them past the worst of the rough country. As they crest, they finally have line of sight on the cult camp ahead.
7. The path dies at a small ravine. To press on means a careful climb down; to detour around it means more time in the shadows with three of them blind in the dark. Eguzkilore points out that night-blind movement compounds; they take the descent.
8. Nuberroca goes down first, then turns to catch the rest. Nyx loses footing partway down and clings until the goliath reaches up and steadies her. The descent costs them time but nobody is hurt.
9. Amidamaru and Nyx are still hauling themselves over the worst of the climb when Mialee and Nuberroca have already cleared it. Between Nuberroca's reach and Sinsong's casting, the group makes it down without injury, though it costs them a full hour and dawn is far off.

2 - Through the gate

1. The camp sits in a horseshoe of high hills, two terraces wrapped around a lower bowl. A makeshift gate parapet at the entrance holds two crossbowmen behind cover and four guards on the path itself. A handful of stunted watchtowers and a single proper tower at the bowl's heart break the skyline. Tents and torch-fires are scattered across the floor.
2. Stragglers from the Greenest raid are still trickling in past the gate — wounded, laden, slow. The watch barely glances at them.
3. The heroes measure the gate against themselves: six of them against several hundred. Even Nuberroca, who would rather charge, is talked down. Mialee lays out three options — observe from outside the bowl; bluff in through the gate as cultists; or sneak in unseen.
4. Two of them are already dressed in cultists' robes from the previous day's loot; only Sinsong and Eguzkilore can pass unchallenged. Nuberroca and Amidamaru are too distinctive to disguise — they would draw eyes the moment they reached the gate. The party splits.
5. Sinsong walks in calmly through the gate; Eguzkilore follows a few paces behind. Amidamaru lays a Guidance on Sinsong before he goes, telling him with a hand on the shoulder that his charisma will carry him through. The cultists at the gate barely look at them; the gate-stragglers are constant and disorganised.
6. The first ring of the camp is a triage zone — rough cots, makeshift tents, walking wounded. Most of the wounds are *superficial*; the keep's defenders did not score deeply.
7. Past the triage they catch sight of giant lizards being led inwards: the drakes used as pack beasts, hauling looted goods deeper into the camp. They drift along behind a group, keeping the lizards at the comfortable middle distance.
8. They reach a tier of more permanent structures — bone-and-hide shelters daubed with crude five-headed dragon symbols, and a stunted tower around which kobolds cluster. The kobolds keep their distance from the human cultists; the human cultists return the courtesy.
9. A ranked cultist stops them. *"¿Quién era el dragonclaw a cargo de vuestra operación?"* Sinsong stalls — he is bad with names — and improvises that they have to go back outside, that they forgot a piece of plunder on the road and his idiot companion is going to pay for leaving it. Eguzkilore catches up just in time, plays along, smacks Sinsong in the back of the head to sell the bit, and hauls him out.
10. The cultist lets them go. They walk back to the gate at the same unhurried pace they came in at and slip back out into the dark.

3 – On the high plateau

1. The other four trace the camp's outer wall along the high plateau, climbing the steeper escarpment to the ridge that overlooks the bowl. The ascent is rough — Mialee and Nuberroca top it cleanly; Nyx and Amidamaru both struggle with the night-blind climb until Nuberroca reaches down and hauls them up. The whole climb costs them about an hour.
2. From the ridge they can see the bowl in full. The high terrace runs along the rim; the bowl interior is dotted with cooking fires and the mobile lights of inner patrols. There is *no patrol at all* on the high plateau — whether by lazy oversight or by design, they cannot tell.
3. Nyx works a rough sketch of the camp into a scrap of parchment by torchlight, ink from her own kit, a quill cobbled together from one of Mialee's arrow-flights.
4. Searching for tracks on the high terrace, Nyx finds nothing suspicious — no kobold, no drake, no human. Only animal sign. The cultists either do not patrol up here, or they prefer not to be seen doing so.
5. Nyx Messages Sinsong to check whether they got through cleanly. Sinsong answers that they came out without a problem at all — the cultists swallowed the story whole, smooth as anything. Mialee proposes the two halves rejoin by the inside group circling around to the high plateau.
6. Sinsong and Eguzkilore work their way around to where the climb starts; following the rest of the party's tracks through the dark, the two of them only need an hour to cover what the first group spent two on. They rejoin near the rim of the camp.
7. The party is exhausted and intends a long rest. The high terrace has a generous supply of small caves; many are half-buried by old rockfall and brush, more than enough cover for a halfling-led party to disappear into.
8. Before sleeping Nyx prepares a fistful of magical berries — the party's emergency food and healing — and presses one into each companion's hand.
9. They sleep the rest of the night with no disturbance, waking up refreshed.

4 – The morning camp

~08:00, 24 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. They wake to the bowl in full daylight. The trickle of stragglers at the gate has all but stopped; the wounded are mostly back on their feet, bandaged but functional. Four small parties of hunters — three or four men each, armed with traps and crossbows — leave the gate and disperse out into the surrounding country to forage. The party guesses the camp itself has stripped the local game, and they have not seen any animal sign worth mentioning on the trail in.
2. Sinsong sets a magical sensor floating out and downwards over the camp, granting them a bird's-eye sweep without exposing themselves on the rim.
3. Through the sensor they pick out the *prisoner detail* — eight wretches in chains being broken into two groups of four, set to cleaning latrines. Mialee asks whether any of them might be a half-elf monk, but the sensor cannot tell from above.
4. Cultists in heavy packs are streaming inward toward the camp's east end and coming back without their loads. The route ends at a heavily-guarded cave at the far east of the bowl. Whatever the cult is gathering, the cave is where it is gathering it.

5 – Finding Leosin

1. Working closer along the rim, the party spots a man tied to a stake against the bowl wall — bloodied, malnourished, slumped. From his bearing and his clothes Mialee makes him for a monk.
2. Nyx sends a mental message asking whether he is Leosin, telling him to stay calm — they are friends, sent by his apprentice, and he can answer her in his mind if he prefers. The man's head lifts as if hearing a voice from nowhere. He answers that his name is **Leosin Erlanthar**; he does not know whether he is the one they are looking for.
3. Asked how long he has been there, Leosin says since the start of the assault on Greenest — about two days. Asked how he was caught, he answers without flinching: he let himself be captured; he needed to *infiltrate*. Nyx asks dryly whether it has been working out for him; he says he has gathered a great deal already, and that he has his own ways out.
4. The party offers help anyway. Leosin accepts the offer of a free hand: if they can untie him without drawing attention, he will manage the rest.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Mialee, from cover on the rim, conjures her invisible arcane hand and walks it down the cliff and across the camp floor, arriving at the stake without a single cultist seeing her. The hand picks loose the knots one by one. Leosin nearly stumbles when the cord goes slack and recovers, miming bound shoulders so cleanly that nothing in his posture gives him away.
6. Sinsong, from the rim, calls a quiet healing on the monk. The effect *runs noticeably further than the spell ought to carry* — Leosin's worst cuts close, the slump leaves his shoulders, and the bruise and hunger of two days lift off him in a single beat.
7. Eguzkilore, who has watched the whole rescue, asks Nyx to ask Leosin whether they should set a meeting place outside the camp; before Leosin can answer, the monk takes one careful look around for inattentive cultists and slips into a tent. He is gone before the question lands.
8. The party decides to create a distraction to help the monk escape. Mialee proposes a fire on the rim itself, drawing eyes up and away from the prisoner stakes.
9. Nuberroca asks Sinsong whether he can burn one of the tents. The dwarf, after gauging the distance, agrees it is just within range; he hurls a bolt of fire down at the cluster of inner tents at the eastern end. The tent ignites; black smoke rises immediately. Nuberroca claps Sinsong on the shoulder — well done, about time.
10. Below, a horn-call goes up from the central tower. The fire spreads along the canvas. Cultists run to put it out; others look upward to find the source. Two of them notice the party silhouetted on the rim and start pointing.
11. One of the cultists begins to climb the cliff face — a slow scramble. Sinsong, watching him come up, levels another bolt of flame and drops the man before he reaches the top.

6 – Four from the tent

1. The horn brings out the camp's leadership. Out of the largest tent — a permanent-looking structure ringed by drake-handlers — emerge **four figures**. Eguzkilore takes a moment to place the first; the party recognises him from Greenest: **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath**, the blue half-dragon.
2. Beside Langdedrosa stands a much larger figure: a *black half-dragon*, female by build, clearly senior to the rest.
3. The third is a tall human in red robes, his head shaved and tattooed in a style none of the party recognises — visibly a *mage*, clearly not from this region.
4. The fourth is another human, robed half as a soldier and half as a scholar, also reading as a caster.
5. The red-robed mage looks up at the rim, makes a small gesture, and a sword of *pale blue light* blooms into existence beside Sinsong on the cliff edge. Before Sinsong can react it cuts him cleanly across the side. Nuberroca lunges to grab it, but his hand passes through the blade as through smoke.
6. Nuberroca points Sinsong toward the central tent — just within his range — but Sinsong commits the cast against the red mage instead, and a bolt of fire goes back down the rim. The mage scarcely shifts, makes another small gesture, and the worst of the heat passes him by. The conjured sword stays beside Sinsong, swinging at him.
7. *Why don't we just leave*, Nyx says, and that decides it. The party breaks east along the high plateau, away from the climbable face of the cliff and toward open country.
8. The veteran guards ringing the central tent loose three bolts upward at the rim. All three break against the rocks — the party's height advantage on the cliff defeats the angle.
9. The conjured sword paces Sinsong as he runs; it is faster than a man's walk but slower than a sprint. Nuberroca scoops Sinsong under one arm and Dashes east, taking the goliath's full stride at speed; the sword cannot keep up and dissolves several breaths behind them. The gash the sword left along Sinsong's side has stopped bleeding by the time they reach broken country.
10. About a mile back from the rim, the party drops into broken country and Nyx erases their trail behind them — quartering a path, doubling back over rock, picking the line a halfling raised on tracker's craft can pick.

7 - The wounded deer

1. The party reviews what they have. **Tarbaw** asked for four things: the cult's motivations, leaders, numbers, and plans. They have the first three. The motivation they can guess at — *gathering treasure for the glory of Tiamat* — but their plan is unknown.
2. Amidamaru and Eguzkilore both vote to fall back to Greenest. Nuberroca wants to lay an ambush and start wearing the camp down patrol by patrol — pick them off and string the bodies up in the surrounding woods to break their morale. Mialee tells him that would just bring the whole camp out in force. The vote falls on returning. They begin to walk west.
3. Half a mile on, a wounded deer crashes through the brush ahead of them and collapses on the rocks. The deer is fresh-bleeding and broken; whatever scared it is close behind.
4. Eguzkilore draws his bow and crouches behind cover; the rest take whatever shelter they can find on the broken ground. Amidamaru works himself into a fissure. Mialee notches an arrow and waits.
5. Two drakes burst through the brush on the deer's tail, the four hunters trailing behind them. The drakes are faster than their handlers and reach the open ground first. Mialee's arrow hits the lead drake before any of the hunters has registered the party.
6. Eguzkilore puts a second shot on the same drake. Nuberroca, hidden behind a tree on the high ground, swings his greataxe at the closest drake and misses badly — the axe buries itself in the trunk and refuses to come free. The lead drake's first snap catches him in the side as he hauls at the haft; a *blue glow* runs across the bite and closes it partway. He spends the next round wrestling the weapon out of the wood.
7. The hunters have crossbows out before the drakes are halfway across the open ground. They take cover behind whatever they can find — a tree, a rock, the carcass of one of their own drakes once Mialee drops it. The shooting is steady and hard.
8. The drakes converge on Nuberroca, who is the largest threat in sight. They take him at the tree, biting and tail-whipping; a *blue glow* runs across each fresh tear as it opens, but the damage outpaces it and the goliath drops unconscious in seconds. Eguzkilore breaks cover, crosses the open and stabilises Nuberroca on the ground.
9. Sinsong calls down a blessing on three of his companions and pours a healing potion on Nuberroca — the goliath sits up still bleeding but conscious.
10. Two of the hunters close to knife range against the party at the tree line while the other two hold the rocks with their crossbows. Amidamaru flanks one of the knife-fighters from behind and lays in two daggers between the ribs; the man takes the hits but stays upright. Mialee's follow-up sneak shot punches through and drops him dead in the dust.
11. The second knife-fighter shifts to Eguzkilore and lands a critical strike that nearly puts him down — the gash along his ribs *mends to a slow ooze* before he can press a hand to it. Before the man can finish the job, Amidamaru circles in behind him and lays in two more daggers, this time held flat for non-lethal blows; the hunter crumples unconscious, breathing but barely. The party will keep this one for questioning.
12. The drake's bite-and-tail-whip catches Eguzkilore in the open and drops him; Sinsong moves up and stabilises him swiftly.
13. Mialee hits the second drake; Nyx turns her Hunter's Mark onto it. Between the two of them the drake falls dead off the rock.
14. The two crossbow hunters at the rocks fire one last volley at Amidamaru — both miss — and break for the broken country behind their position. Mialee's sneak shot wings the trailing one in mid-retreat and leaves him reeling but on his feet. He hesitates a beat, then breaks into a sprint.
15. Nuberroca's first lunge after the runner falls short by a few yards. The goliath *dissolves into cloud* and reappears beside the runner a single step later, bringing the greataxe down. The man does not get back up. The fourth hunter slips away into the broken country before anyone can catch him.
16. With the field clear, Amidamaru darts to Eguzkilore and presses one of Nyx's berries between his lips; the elf opens his eyes, alive but barely. Total tally: two drakes dead, two hunters dead, one alive and bound, one escaped into the country. The party catches the deer, dresses it for travel and saves the meat.

8 - The interrogation

1. The bound hunter wakes feet-up against the rock-face, four armed strangers around him and a deer being butchered nearby. Nyx tries the gentle line first: *"buenos días, majo. Has tenido mala suerte. Queremos que nos digas un par de cositas y te dejamos ir."* The cultist's reply is cold — he will never tell them anything.
2. Nuberroca steps in still slick with the last hunter's blood, the greataxe across his shoulder, and Nyx says, *"mira, este es mi amigo. Si no nos dices lo que queremos saber, va a hacer lo suyo."* The cultist breaks.
3. He names his commander first — **Rezmir**, a black half-dragon, female, the chief of this camp. He confirms **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** when Nuberroca asks for him by name: a blue half-dragon, rigid honour — not someone you would want to anger.
4. Pressed on the line of command, the cultist offers a third name on his own — **Frulam Mondath**. Langdedrosa, he says, is Frulam's right hand; Frulam in turn answers to Rezmir.
5. Asked about the red-robed mage, the cultist says he does not know the man. Nyx watches him as he says it and judges he is *lying* — there is something about the red-robed figure he is hiding.
6. Asked for numbers, the cultist puffs himself up — *"somos legión. Somos más de los que podréis jamás derrotar y somos más de los que podréis contar. Y cada día somos más."* — and lands on five thousand. Pressed harder he concedes that this camp itself is fewer than that, and that he and the dead hunters were not even formal members of the cult, just hired scouts feeding the camp.
7. Asked the cult's purpose, he gives the line they have heard before — the glory of Tiamat. Asked why Greenest, he says it was the largest city closest to the camp and the raid has been an absolute success. Asked the next target, he claims that is above his rank.
8. Asked where the cult was before Greenest, the cultist refuses. He offers a deal: release him, let him reach a safe distance, and he will shout the answer back across the rocks.
9. Sinsong refuses outright — let him go and he will run straight to the camp. Mialee laughs; Eguzkilore stays out of it. Nyx insists she gave the man her word and will not break it. Nuberroca defers to her — little one, what is your call. She nods. Nuberroca lifts the man bodily, walks him to a clear stretch of rock, and puts him down gently.
10. The cultist runs. Sinsong reaches with the staff for a non-lethal blow as the man passes; the strike misses. The hunter Dashes a hundred and twenty feet across open ground, turns, cups his hands to his mouth and shouts back — *from the east!*
11. Sinsong's bolt of fire travels the full hundred and twenty feet and catches him. The hunter falls and does not get up. Mialee says, flat, that what he just did was *wrong*. Sinsong shrugs — they are capable of tracking us.

9 - Back to Greenest

~11:00, 24 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party gathers what gear they need. Forty rations of butchered venison go on Nuberroca's back; the goliath gives Sinsong ten and keeps the rest, complaining about the weight more than the pain.
2. Nyx takes the hunters' arrows — the half that survived the volleys — back into her quiver. Eguzkilore takes a few. Nuberroca tries to claim a crossbow and is talked out of it. He keeps four hand-axes off the dead drakes' handlers and a small leather pouch of mundane junk.
3. Nyx covers their tracks again on the way out, then leads them north along the rim and west around the bowl, keeping the cult camp well off their north shoulder. They cross the foothills back into farmland by mid-morning.
4. They reach Greenest at about half past three. The town is still in its post-assault state — fewer wounded out in the streets, the cremations long since done, the soldiers visibly less ragged.

10 – Report and reward

~15:30, 24 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The party stops at the keep's modest armoury before reporting in. Nuberroca trades one of his old hand-axes back, claims a proper shield and accepts that an old pickaxe sells for a single piece of gold. Eguzkilore replenishes arrows.
2. Three healing potions sit on the keep's small market table at fifty gold a piece — a discounted hero's price. Amidamaru sets aside ten gold for incense; he intends to bind a familiar soon. The rest of the purchases wait on **Tarbaw**'s reward.
3. Tarbaw receives them in the side room. Mialee opens the report — camp twelve miles south, rough strength two hundred to three hundred, a handful of leaders. Nyx fills in: Langdedrosa Cyanwrath, Rezmir the black half-dragon as chief, a red-robed mage they could not name and Frulam Mondath named under interrogation. Cultists of Tiamat. Treasure piled up at a heavily-guarded cave at the camp's east end. Eight prisoners cleaning latrines; Leosin Erlanthar found and freed; his fate after that unknown.
4. Asked the cult's intent, Nyx repeats the line she has been given: glory to Tiamat. Greenest as the largest city closest to the camp and a confirmed successful raid. She offers her own guess that the line is what the rank-and-file believe and that the leaders may want something else; she also offers her guess at the next target — based on the cultist's last shout, eastward in origin and possibly westward in plan, with Candlekeep and Baldur's Gate as the obvious large-city candidates. Tarbaw does not commit to a route but says he will warn the city watch.
5. Tarbaw counts out **two hundred pieces of gold for each of them** out of the keep coffers. Mialee sets aside a hundred of hers and pushes it back across the table — for the town. Nuberroca produces twenty rations of venison and adds them to the same pile. The governor praises their honour.
6. The party splits the remaining potions: one to Amidamaru, one to Sinsong, one to Nyx. Amidamaru sits in the keep's outer yard with the incense and works the binding ritual. An hour later, a small owl familiar perches on his shell.